XP and pet shop: testing reflection

7 October 2026 | Scope: health/XP display, item unlocks and saved ownership

What was tested, and why

Testing focused on whether the new interface reliably communicates progress and lets players collect eligible items. The agreed rule was that XP unlocks items without being spent. Automated checks ran in an isolated Unity project, followed by inspection of rendered screens. No participant usability study was conducted.

Unlock rules and saving. Checks covered free starter items, rejection below an XP threshold, successful collection at the exact threshold, unchanged XP, duplicate and unknown-item rejection, and persistence after reloading. Older saves were checked for compatibility. A deliberately damaged save tested whether a failed write could incorrectly grant ownership. These checks targeted the risk of losing progress or presenting a reward that had not actually saved.

Navigation and presentation. Checks covered loading individual asset-pack sprites, unique item IDs, the menu-to-shop flow, category filtering, the Back button and re-enabling the screen. Rendered layouts at 390 x 844, 320 x 568 and 844 x 390 tested whether health, XP and the shop remained within the background.

What the results revealed

The C# build completed with no warnings or errors, and the final Unity validation suite passed. Ownership survived reloading and profile updates; failed saving left ownership unchanged. An initial landscape test failed because the shop list had too little space. Scaling the interface with the fitted background resolved that layout check.

However, fitting inside the background is a weaker success criterion than being usable. The landscape preview still shows very small text and controls because the portrait background becomes narrow. The technical pass therefore supports functional correctness, but does not establish comfortable reading or touch interaction.

Lessons and next steps

1. Test understanding and readability first. Run a small formative playtest on physical phones. Ask players to find the shop, explain a locked item, collect an unlocked item and return to the pet without prompting. Record confusion, mis-taps and whether they expect XP to decrease. Use the findings to revise labels, touch targets and the landscape layout.

2. Give progression a meaningful basis. Current thresholds increase by sprite groups; they are provisional, not evidence of balanced progression. Tie unlocks to intended learning activities, then test whether the pace feels clear and achievable. This iteration does not demonstrate educational or behavioural benefit.

3. Complete the reward loop before expanding the catalogue. Items currently record ownership only; furniture placement, supply use and XP-earning activities are not implemented here. Add one complete earn-unlock-collect-use interaction, then test save/reload behaviour and whether the reward supports the activity. This will provide stronger evidence than adding more items alone.

Evidence: Tools/PetShopValidation.cs; Unity validation log; rendered gameplay/shop previews.